

SANJANA GHOSH

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EMPLOYMENT

Ashoka University, Sonapat, India
Assistant Professor

July 2026 – Present

EDUCATION

Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University, IL, US
Ph.D. in Managerial Economics and Strategy

2020-2026

Indian Statistical Institute, New Delhi, India
MSc. in Quantitative Economics

2015-2017

Jadavpur University, Kolkata, India
BA. in Economics

2012-2015

FIELDS

Primary: Environmental and Energy Economics

Secondary: Corporate Finance, Industrial Organization, Development Economics

RESEARCH

Working Papers

- Losing the Shield: How Political Connections Shape Environmental Enforcement (with Elena Stella)

Abstract: This paper provides novel evidence on how political connections distort environmental regulatory enforcement in the Maharashtrian Sugar industry, using a unique natural experiment that creates simultaneous bidirectional variation in political access. We exploit the 2022 political crisis in Maharashtra, India, which caused some sugar mills to suddenly lose cabinet access while others gained it. Combining novel data on regulatory punishment, environmental & operational outcomes for sugar mills, we find that mills losing political access experience significantly higher enforcement rates, while mills gaining connections face no change in regulatory pressure. This effect is driven entirely by discretionary enforcement rather than complaint-driven inspections. We further disentangle capture from changes in underlying compliance behaviour of mills using granular emissions monitoring data. We find that our main results are not driven by changes in environmental compliance by mills who lose cabinet access, while mills gaining connections significantly reduce compliance yet face no regulatory consequences. These findings demonstrate systematic heterogeneity in environmental enforcement in a weak institution setting.

- Voice Until the Last Exit: Ownership Structure and the Limits of Voluntary Environmental Commitments (with Leo Jean & Pritam Saha)

Abstract: The effectiveness of corporate climate initiatives depends not only on firms' commitments but also on existing asset ownership structure. We study this question in the context of the World Bank's Zero Routine Flaring by 2030 initiative, under which oil and gas companies pledge to eliminate routine flaring from their assets. Using asset-level ownership and satellite-based flaring measurements for nearly 20,000 oil and gas assets worldwide (2012–2024), we exploit staggered firm endorsements to study how committed firms navigate the tradeoff between voice, exercising governance influence to reduce emissions, and exit, divesting from assets that are costly to decarbonize. Committed ownership reduces flaring gradually but persistently, reaching approximately 45% below pre-commitment levels after nine years. The persistence of these gains hinges on continued committed presence: when the last committed owner divests, flaring rises by roughly 40% within two years and exceeds 90% within six years, a result we term the "last good owner effect." Retaining at least one committed voice on the board is both necessary and sufficient to sustain emissions discipline.

- Misallocation in Electricity Markets and Economic Development

Abstract: This paper studies whether politically driven cross-subsidies in electricity pricing—low tariffs for agricultural users financed by high industrial tariffs—distort structural transformation in India. I assemble a new state-year panel that recovers category-specific electricity prices and sectoral employment to quantify how cross-subsidies shape structural transformation in India. Using a shift-share instrument interacting national coal price movements with state thermal-generation shares, reflecting Coal India’s nationally set coal prices that pass through to power costs, I find that increases in the industrial–agricultural price wedge reallocate employment away from manufacturing toward agriculture. These findings suggest that electricity cross-subsidies can hinder manufacturing-led structural transformation by raising the relative cost of operating capital, with implications for the design of politically salient but distortionary tariff policies.

CONFERENCES & SEMINARS

- **2026:** CSW Asia Meeting (Main) (NYU Abu Dhabi), 2026 Northeast Workshop on Energy Policy and Environmental Economics (Boston College), 15th Toulouse Conference on Energy and Climate Economics (Toulouse School of Economics)
- **2025:** North East Universities Development Consortium (Tufts), 20th Annual Conference on Economic Growth and Development (ISI Delhi)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Ashoka (Undergraduate)

- Environmental Economics 2026-Present

Teaching Assistant at Kellogg (MBA)

- The Economics of Energy Markets and the Environment 2021-2025
- Core Strategy 2021-2025
- Business Analytics I/II 2023-2024

ACADEMIC WORKSHOPS

- 2023 Price Theory Summer Camp
- 2022 Barcelona School of Economics - Summer School in Development Economics (Geospatial Tools for Development: Data and Inference)
- 2021 Berkeley/Sloan Summer School in Environmental and Energy Economics

REFeree SERVICES

- Journal of the Association of Environmental and Resource Economists

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

- Weiss Travel Grant (\$4200, with Elena Stella)